

FREE FOR ELKINS PARK HOMEOWNERS

The Pre-List *Profit* Checklist

What actually adds to your sale price, what just wastes your money, and what a buyer's inspector will find in an older Elkins Park home.

Here's what almost nobody tells you before you list: **most of what sellers spend getting ready, they never get back.** The kitchen gets redone, a bathroom gets gutted, and the offer comes in right where it would have anyway, because the sales on your street set the ceiling, not the invoice.

In the Marine Corps, I was an aviation Quality Assurance inspector: nothing flew until every part and every system had been verified. Selling a house works the same way. So this isn't a "fix everything" list. It's the **short list that moves your price**, the list to skip, and the few things to know before a buyer's inspector writes them up for you.

Check them off as you go.



RUBEN ZAPATA
USMC Veteran · Roberts Rd neighbor

Do these THEY COME BACK TO YOU

Seven things, most of them cheap, that change how every showing and every listing photo feels.

- | | | |
|--------------------------|--|---|
| ☐ | 1. Deep clean and declutter.
Clear the counters and the closets (buyers open them), then one professional clean. Close to free, and the biggest payoff on this page. | COST: \$
PAYOFF: HIGHEST |
| ☐ | 2. Neutral paint, only where it's needed.
Not the whole house. Just the dark, bold or dated rooms. They read bigger and brighter in photos and in person. | COST: \$\$
PAYOFF: HIGH |
| ☐ | 3. Win the first eight seconds.
Clean front door, working hardware, a fresh mat, trimmed bushes. It's the first listing photo and the first thing they see in person. | COST: \$
PAYOFF: HIGH |
| ☐ | 4. Fix the small stuff before the inspector finds it.
Running toilet, dripping faucet, loose railing, cracked outlet cover. Ten small items on a report make a buyer nervous and start a negotiation. Fix them now for a fraction of what they'd cost you later. | COST: \$
PAYOFF: PROTECTS PRICE |
| ☐ | 5. Let the light in.
Open every blind, wash the windows, swap dim or dead bulbs for bright ones. Bright homes photograph better and show better. | COST: \$
PAYOFF: HIGH |
| ☐ | 6. A tended yard, nothing fancy.
Spring and summer: mow, edge, fresh mulch. Fall and winter: leaves raked, walks cleared, a light on at the door. You don't need landscaping. You need it to look cared for. | COST: \$
PAYOFF: MEDIUM |
| ☐ | 7. Have your paperwork ready.
Fill out the PA Seller's Property Disclosure carefully, and gather permits, warranties, repair receipts and utility costs. It heads off the late surprises that reopen a deal. | COST: FREE
PAYOFF: SMOOTHER CLOSE |

Skip these **RARELY PAY OFF**

Money you spend here usually raises the next owner's home value, not your price.

- ☒ **A full kitchen remodel**
Clean, new hardware and paint gets most of the visual win for a small slice of the cost. Many buyers want to pick their own finishes anyway.
- ☒ **A high-end bathroom gut**
Fix what's broken, re-caulk, clean the grout. Don't demo.
- ☒ **Finishing the basement "for resale"**
Do it because you want it, not because you think a buyer will pay you back.
- ☒ **Bold, personal upgrades**
What you love, the next buyer may see as something to undo.
- ☒ **Anything past the top of your street**
Every block has a price ceiling. Spend past it and you won't see it back.

Know these first **OLDER-HOME EDITION**

Elkins Park has beautiful older homes, and these four come up at inspection again and again. Far cheaper and calmer to know now than three days before closing.

- ☐ **Wiring**
Knob-and-tube or ungrounded outlets get flagged, and some insurers and lenders ask about them. Know what's behind your walls.
- ☐ **Roof age**
Near the end of its life? Buyers and their lenders will notice. Find your install date or get a quick look.
- ☐ **The sewer line**
Older clay lines crack and let roots in. A camera scope now is cheap; a surprise during a deal is not.
- ☐ **Radon**
Our region tests high often enough that many buyers check. A simple test tells you where you stand.

Your 6-week runway **FALL, WINTER OR SPRING****WEEKS 6-5**

Walk-through with me. Order any roof, sewer or radon checks. Book contractors.

WEEKS 4-3

Small repairs done. Paint the rooms that need it. Start decluttering.

WEEK 2

Curb appeal, front door, bulbs, windows. Paperwork and disclosure gathered.

WEEK 1

Deep clean, blinds open, professional photos. You're ready.

Listing this fall or winter? Fewer neighbors put their homes on the market, so yours faces less competition, and the buyers still out looking are usually serious. **Aiming for spring?** Start this runway about six weeks before you want to go live, and you'll hit the busy season ready.



USMC AVIATION QA INSPECTOR



YOUR NEIGHBOR

Want the version for *your* house?

I'm Ruben Zapata. In the Marine Corps I worked on F/A-18 fighter jets, then became a Quality Assurance inspector, verifying every part and system on F/A-18s, MV-22 Ospreys and CH-53 Super Stallions before they flew. The Marines asked me to stay. I brought that standard to real estate instead. I live on Roberts Rd, so this isn't a sales territory to me. It's home.

Every house is different. A 15-minute walk-through tells you more than any checklist, so I'll come by and tell you which of these actually matter for your home, and which you can skip. **No cost, no pressure, ever.**

Text **WALK** to 570-701-9106 and we'll pick a time.

Ruben Zapata, REALTOR® · 570-701-9106 | Compass RE · 267-435-8015

Q&U Team at Compass · ruben.zapata@compass.com

COMPLIANCE BLOCK - Q&U / Compass to supply (office address, license # if required, Equal Housing Opportunity logo)